Between Dusts and Stars

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Prologue: The Procrastination Syndrome

COL-307001

An icy wind blasts you in the face, and a mist fogs up your eyes.

You don't know where you are, but with leaden steps you press on.

You can vaguely feel yourself moving to a higher place. You can't stay here. You definitely have to get away.

Look! A thick rope is thrown down from above. Strong and sturdy, it waves at you as it swings in the wind.

Your legs are trembling, your eyes are losing focus, and your blood is running cold. You stop and you hesitate.

An escape. Reach for it?

Choices

1. Grab on. You have nothing to lose.

2. Ignore it. Even the dying should remain dignified.

Branch 1

> You reach for the rope and hold on for dear life. You would have grabbed it with your teeth if you could.
>
> Sadly, it's not as sturdy as it looks. CRACK! You hear the snap of a fishing line.

Branch 2

> You kneel down and begin to crawl, chest swelling with pride. Your mouth is dry, but it's as if you are drinking from a delicious spring.
>
> The unrelenting wind hits you and sweeps you towards the edge of the cliff.

Shared continuation

Suddenly you're falling! Panic and fear overwhelm you and take hold of your mind.

Research Laboratory

Kaalaa Baunaa: ——!

Late at night in the research institute, all is quiet as usual.

The documents and proposals under your arms have been there for too long. They were probably the cause of the nightmare.

Kaalaa Baunaa: 04:15... I slept for almost 4 hours?!

Kaalaa Baunaa: It was supposed to be a quick nap...

You hear faint snoring from all around—the rest of the staff is sound asleep.

Kaalaa Baunaa: *deep breath* Wake up, Kaalaa. The deadline is coming sooner than I thought ...

Gnawed Cereal Bar

COL-307002

Half a cereal bar lies on the table, dry, stale, and half exposed. It doesn't look very appetizing.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's from the day before yesterday... Well, beggars can't be choosers.

Kaalaa Baunaa: *chews* Hmm, it tastes...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Much better than I thought ... Lucky.

You examine the cereal bar and notice that something's a bit...off...

Researcher Daksha: Gaurav! Now the whole team has to pay for your screw up!

Researcher Daksha: You can't even distinguish a single star from a binary star?! What academy in its right mind ever let you in? Cowbridge?

Intern Gaurav: S-Sorry!

Researcher Himani: And we're working in an institution, not a pet store. Remember to tie it to the door ...

Even the smallest mistake can result in a sleepless night for everyone.

Intern Gaurav: Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa...

You take the coffee with both hands.

The overly enthusiastic puppy is still at your knees, oblivious to the unpleasant state of affairs.

Kaalaa Baunaa: These telescopes are our eyes, using thousands of years of observational data to guide us as we peer into the depths of the universe.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Well, we have never seen it with our "own eyes", though.

Intern Gaurav: But I'm sure I—

Kaalaa Baunaa: —Again, please do NOT forget to conduct analysis on the changes in the spectral lines. They should be treated like your second pair of eyes.

Intern Gaurav: Yes, miss...

Gaurav lowers his head and pulls a cereal bar out of his pocket, drawing the friendly puppy's attention.

He absent-mindedly feeds the puppy until researchers call him away.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Wait a minute—

Kaalaa Baunaa: You turn the cereal bar over and see jagged, gnawing marks on it...

The Comatose Person

COL-307003

A researcher is fast asleep on the floor. She is breathing steadily like a baby, only her adult size makes the scene not so adorable or...appropriate.

Choices

1. Wake her up

Kaalaa Baunaa: Go sleep in the conference room, Daksha.

Rubbing her eyes, Daksha doesn't seem to realize where she is.

After finally figuring it out, she jumps to her feet in great surprise.

Researcher Daksha: Oh gosh... Did I fall asleep on the floor?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Why don't you go home? I thought you already finished the report.

Researcher Daksha: No, Kumar gave me some new "suggestions" for my research direction ... I have to start all over again.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ... She did that again?!

Researcher Daksha: This is going to be my last project here ... That's right ... I should've done this earlier ...

With that, she buries herself in research, ignoring you. You take a deep breath and walk away.

White Paper Ball

COL-307004

These crumpled drafts are research waste. They are now in the trash.

A yellowed piece of paper catches your attention. Something you threw away, what was it again?

Choices

1. Pick it up.

2. Not interested.

Branch 1

"Kaalaa Baunaa: Fresh off a promotion, the Senior Researcher Daane formally challenges you! The loser of the Aryabhata Award will be at the winner's beck and call for hot coffee! -Daane."

You snort disdainfully, crumple it into a ball, and throw it back in the trash.

Branch 2

You already forgot what it is about, but apparently, you didn't like it.

Not in the mood. Just let garbage lie where it belongs.

Epilogue: The Procrastination Syndrome

COL-307005

Now that you're fully awake, it's time to get back to work.

Choices

1. No, I need another five minutes.

2. Go straight back to your desk.

Branch 1

It's pitch black outside the institute, but compared to this enclosed, suffocating space, the open air might offer a breath of inspiration...

We could always use a little inspiration, my friend. Focusing too much on work will only scare the muse away.

Branch 2

You embark on your ten-meter journey, an arduous, terrifying expedition strewn with difficulties, accidents, and even danger...

As you walk across the moonlit ground, you can't help but look up. The next second, your mind is flying amongst the stars in the boundless sky.

Stop!

Sto—

Shared continuation

...

You are already outside the gates when you come to your senses. You are greeted by something that transcends work—the limitless universe.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...How long has it been since I came here?

The countless days and nights observing the stars within the confines of the institute...

Kaalaa Baunaa: I forgot how much I have to crane my neck to see the stars.

But when I bury my head in data, I can discover so much more.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I should come here more often.

But, there's always something pressing at hand.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Such a rare opportunity...

The urgent proposals are—

Kaalaa Baunaa: I should be able to find all those stars again.

"Thud." You collapse, and all your worries fade into the background.

But simply ignoring and dodging problems won't help you get rid of that terrible monster...

Inside the institution, the proposals you ignored are starting to groan ...

They can no longer stand this deliberate neglect. Driven by hunger, they grow larger and larger as they search for the one to blame ...

Until finally, they break the restraints of their vessel and come after you with ravenous intent...

3#1

Prologue: Twinkling Stars

COL-307006

Kaalaa Baunaa: Sirius, Betelgeuse ... They look so close to each other in the eyes of mankind ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: ... But they are actually over 600 light years apart.

Whether immersed in the boundless universe, an expansive plain, or a quiet bathroom...one cannot escape the contemplation of life.

Under the cover of the starry night, the hungry "beasts" crawl to your side, entangling your legs ...

Proposal: Hungry ... Hungry! Forbid ... project, delay &%*&*...!

Kaalaa Baunaa: What...?!

Countless ravenous hands grab hold of you, trying to drag you back to that terrifying lair known as the research institute...

Such is the fate of the procrastinator ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Relaxing is important for—

Proposal: Deadline &%*&* ...

You struggle to run away, but they just won't let you go ...

Darkness envelops your eyes and you feel yourself being dragged back to work.

You can neither stop nor turn around ... The only thing you can do now is to prevent yourself from being crushed further in this mental car crash.

Pile of Documents

COL-307007

Looking at the piles of data, you are feeling at a loss.

But you have to take the first step anyway. Now start the engine of your brain and try to keep up with your hands ...

Choices

1. Organize data

Kaalaa Baunaa: The data in May. We saw nothing that day thanks to the dark clouds ...

You remember that day. A bunch of children swarmed into the observatory, surrounded the telescopes and equipment, and poked around curiously.

Observatory

They were children of wealthy families; some were children of professors, others were invited because of their parents' generous donations to Banner University.

Ordinary children had to pay a higher price to observe the universe. But she knew that, distracted by shiny new discoveries, the kids would soon pay no attention to the dreariness of this place.

Teacher: Unfortunately, because of the bad weather, we have to come here another day.

The children sighed in unison, and hurried to the observatory exit.

One girl stayed, clutching her dirty clothes, staring at the telescope twice her size.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You should go with them.

Girl: Um ... Are you the admin here? I love this big girl. She's beautiful.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Nice taste ... but I'm not the admin.

Girl: That's a relief. The things I had to go through to get here to see this, following those noisy brats and sneaking in behind them and all.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...You know this place is over 20 km from the foot of the mountain, don't you? Is no one picking you up?

Girl: I can walk ... May I take a look at the sky, just for a second?

Frowning at the request, you looked at the dark clouds covering the sky, and glanced at the specks of mud on the girl's ankles.

Girl: Pleeeeeeease...

She looked up at you, eyes wide open as if sparkling with tears, and tugged at your clothes.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Promise me you'll take my ride back home.

Girl: Deal!

The memory of her eager gaze and spirited figure brings warmth to the cold institution.

Organizing observational data, analyzing celestial orbits...you seem to have found some of the drive you once had.

Calculator

COL-307008

An unfinished orbit model is shown on the screen. You have to fill in the data one by one and complete the calculation—a tedious task indeed.

Choices

1. Fill in the data.

One row, two rows... Your arms are getting sore, but you're only just getting started.

It's Kumar's requirement that you must enter the observation data yourself, even though the job is supposed to be done by interns ... Her stubbornness has led many colleagues to resign.

Kumar: Hmph, researchers should treat the observation data like their own child. Will you leave your child to the homeless on the street? Sorry, no offense, Gaurav.

Intern Gaurav: ...

Researcher Himani: Kumar, I've already been away from home for two whole days, just to fill in the observation data.

Researcher Himani: Now all I know is, I have a real child at home. I need to take care of him instead of your damn metaphor. I should be with him now, before the nanny puts more funny ideas into his head.

Kumar: So, the solution to your problem is to simply find yourself a nanny or a husband with an education degree, right?

Himani's cheeks flushed red.

Researcher Himani: You know what? I quit. F**k you Kumar!

She stormed out the door. Kumar ordered Gaurav to pack up her things and throw them out like garbage.

Himani is crouched on the ground, sobbing. You walked up to her.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Researcher Himani: ... I won't come back.

With a hand on her forehead, she seemed to be suffering a severe headache.

Researcher Himani: Kumar should know, not everyone is like her... and you, willing to dedicate your whole life to the mysteries of the universe...

Researcher Himani: I have my own life...yet she trampled on my dignity. I will never forgive her.

You never saw her again after that.

Your mind has returned to reality. You look back at the screen, your fingers typing mechanically.

Good. All the data has been filled in to the rhythm of your keystrokes. Now you just need to wait for the big guy to generate the complete model.

Epilogue: Twinkling Stars

COL-307009

Proposal: So full &%*&*... *snores*.

The monster finally quiets down, like a giant beast fallen into a deep slumber. You pack up the documents and turn off the computer.

You know that this is far from over, a nightmare still looms ahead, and you've only cleared one of many hurdles to come...

Kaalaa Baunaa: *sighs*

Your colleagues are about to wake up, yet what you need is a dream in quietude.

You get into the car and isolate yourself. Soon you pass out and sink into the depths of your consciousness.

3#1

Prologue: Confrontation

COL-307010

Bannar University Lecture Hall

In a crowded building, you walk into a classroom and step onto the podium with a file in your hand.

The scrutinizing gazes coming from below are hard to ignore. It feels both familiar and overwhelming.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ... This report given here concerns the work "The Supernova under the Binary Star System of White Dwarf FYDL 82A" ...

Your audience adjusts their posture and listens to your introduction. They have questions, but their professionalism tells them to wait until the end.

Occasionally, they frown at some of your arcane terms, as if this were not a serious academic report.

The rest of the time, they keep a stern face, as they see themselves as academic royalty.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...This concludes this report, thank you for listening.

The audience looks at each other, and the silence in the classroom is deafening.

Proposal: Delicious %*&...

Aside from you, no one notices the monster lurking at the door like the Sword of Damocles.

This is going to be a tough battle ...

Scholar Kapoor

COL-307011

He reads your report carefully, but the content does not dispel the doubt on his face—he seems to be looking at a plate of indescribable food.

Scholar Kapur: First of all, you are an arcanist, right?

They seem to know everything about you.

But you remain calm and collected, as if you've never hidden your identity before.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Yes, but I don't think that has anything to do with my report.

If research proposals can have a fearful, gaping maws, then what's so strange about them knowing a few things about you?

Kaalaa Baunaa: If you look at my signature on the report, it clearly states that I'm an arcanist.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I don't think it's anything to be ashamed of.

You breathe a sigh of relief. You might even say you've waited a long time for this discussion.

Scholar Kapur: Of course! Everyone is welcome to study astronomy. We astronomers have an open mind.

Scholar Kapur: But in your report, I found a lot of trajectory data that are impossible to obtain through observation...

Scholar Kapur: According to scientific assessments, the technology to build any instruments for these observations doesn't yet exist, and the tools we have cannot provide such precise data.

Scholar Kapur: So either you fabricated the data, or you used to so-called "arcane skills" to—

Kaalaa Baunaa: This "unobservable data" was not entirely obtained through arcane skills. I referred to a large number of spectrum analysis and observation reports made by other scholars. Arcane skills only played a very small part in this process.

You interrupt him, frowning at the rudeness of his tone.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You can check the divination data in the past years on page 24. It matches 97% of the data obtained by normal means. The margin of error is perfectly acceptable.

Scholar Kapur: Hmm ... That's what's been written here. Your comparison is ... exhaustive.

He frowns as he flips through the appendix and falls into a long silence. As if to ease the discomfort, he gestures for the next professor to ask questions.

Scholar Lahar

COL-307012

He doesn't try to hide his contempt—it's there for all to see.

Scholar Rahar: I will never approve a report written by an arcanist. I'll say the ideas in your head are hardly worth listening to.

Scholar Rahar: Astrolabe, spice, and hourglass ... It's not a game with my stupid little daughter.

He stands up in anger and puts his hands on the table for support.

Scholar Rahar: If you do the research in a human way, I'll say nothing but welcome. However, you acquired all those data through absurd methods.

You remain unfazed, long accustomed to this.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Sorry, but your objection has nothing to do with the contents of my research. You are just attacking me personally.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I will not respond the way you want, but please allow me to give you a suggestion—respect your daughter.

Burned by the gazes around him, the man flushes and sits down in a panic.

He is a hard nut to crack, but fortunately you still have other choices.

Scholar Dahat

COL-307013

One hand supporting his chin, the other tapping the table, this man seems to be evaluating your report seriously.

Scholar Datt: Could you explain the 3% margin of error in the comparison table between the divination data and the normal observation data?

Scholar Datt: A 3% error is indeed negligible. But I'd like to know if there's a commonality among these inconsistencies.

Scholar Datt: If the commonality is universal, it may indicate that you have manipulated data, or even fabricated results.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You made a valid point...but I don't have the evidence of something I did not do.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I can show you more of the collected data. You can do a random check to see if I faked the conclusion.

Scholar Datt: Alright. I have no further questions.

Scholar Datt: The truth will remain unaffected, whether you are an arcanist or not.

He nods, acknowledging your research.

You can't help but heave a sigh of relief.

Epilogue: Confrontation

COL-307014

You look outside and see the monster reduced to the size of a cat, purring with satisfaction—your speech was remarkably effective.

The crowd disperses, but the next interrogation approaches. You don't have much time to compose yourself.

3#1

Prologue: The Art of Defense

COL-307015

Kaalaa Baunaa: According to the data, the distance between White Dwarf FYDL 82A and its secondary star is gradually decreasing.

Kaalaa Baunaa: They are like two circling marbles falling into the same hole, except they will not collide or separate.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The white dwarf will absorb matter from the secondary star, after which the two will merge, producing a nuclear fusion.

Kaalaa Baunaa: In conclusion, a supernova that is closer to Earth than any other ones in history will take place ...

The professors in the conference room are left speechless and need a few moments to digest this shocking reveal.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Our current data is not enough for simulating the supernova's influence on the Earth's orbit.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But its radiation ... can be destructive to the living things on Earth.

You put down the research report, unsettled by the silence in the conference room.

Do they see the significance of your report? Or are they speechless because they think it's ridiculous?

Or, are they just too shocked to say a single word?

Professor Jardin

COL-307016

Professor Jardin: Your conclusion shocked us, but I suppose you anticipated this.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Yes...

Professor Jardin: Have you considered the possible panic it may cause among the public? If your conjecture is wrong, the institution will become the target of public opinion.

Choices

1. That is not something a researcher needs to consider.

2. Fear and doubt are always present in the search for truth.

Branch 1

Kaalaa Baunaa: It is a researcher's duty to discover and deduce all possibilities. I'm just doing my job.

Kaalaa Baunaa: As for the panic it might cause, that is not part of my consideration.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I am only responsible for ensuring my research report complies with the Research Integrity Agreement.

He strokes his beard, frowning.

Branch 2

Kaalaa Baunaa: The weatherman should not be condemned for predicting a storm.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Doubt, fear... No research can truly be free of these things.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I will take responsibility for the public opinions it may cause. This is a price I'll have to pay.

He sighs, but nods nonetheless.

Professor Chatterjee

COL-307017

Professor Chatterjee: I have no objection to your conclusion. Your data is certainly rigorous.

Professor Chatterjee: But I'm curious. If your prediction is correct, is there any way to protect us from this radiation? Or will you leave this problem to others?

Choices

1. I'm only responsible for finding problems.

2. There is only so much we can do.

Branch 1

Kaalaa Baunaa: This is our progress thus far. As for studying and analyzing the radiation, that's not yet on the agenda.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But if the report is approved, I think I can apply for more funding for further research.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Of course, this is a prediction ... And we know there is a difference between prediction and reality.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I can't be certain that it will go the way I expect.

He breathes a sigh of relief, reassured by your answer. At least he knows you've thought this through.

Branch 2

Kaalaa Baunaa: At this time, we are unable to analyze the composition of the radiation. I have no solution.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It sounds depressing, but it's true. I think our hope lies in further research.

Professor Chatterjee: ...It seems I'll have some nightmares of my own until we figure this out.

He shakes his head, takes off his glasses, and rubs the bridge of his nose.

Professor Rajev

COL-307018

Professor Rajeev: I can't help but see this as a doomsday report.

Professor Rajeev: You have to admit that this report is heavily influenced by the arcanum.

Professor Rajeev: How can I trust an arcanist? I have reason to believe you're using this report to bring arcanists into the public eye to give them prominence, just as some religions do.

Choices

1. That is a prejudiced notion.

2. The data does not lie.

Branch 1

Kaalaa Baunaa: Doom-mongering ... How ridiculous. I'd be a politician inciting the masses if that were true.

Kaalaa Baunaa: And a politician wouldn't need to prove her ideas so rigorously before you.

Professor Rajeev: And who can prove that you're not?

He looks at you intently. You realize there is nothing more you can do.

Branch 2

Kaalaa Baunaa: The movement of celestial bodies is not influenced by my will. It is the observational and comparative data that predict the possibility.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You may think that arcanists are full of lies, but data will always tell you the truth.

Professor Rajeev: A smart answer...

Professor Rajeev: But time will tell what kind of arcanist you are.

Epilogue: The Art of Defense

COL-307019

You let out a long sigh of relief. You survived the inquiry, and the monster at the door is gone.

At least now, you don't have to worry about being dragged back to the institute like a lamb for slaughter.

Hostility and doubts cast aside, the professors give you a few more suggestions, in a gentler way this time.

Obviously, these suggestions are much more useful than their interrogations. It seems you'll have to spend more time perfecting the report …

Kaalaa Baunaa: Whew…

So far you still have not noticed the black star floating above your head …

3#1

Prologue: Either This or That

COL-307020

Back at the institute, you worry over the professors' highlights in the report.

There are still data gaps in the orbital trajectory of the secondary star, but you know this won't be an issue, it's just that…

Examining the observational data will take a lot of energy and time, and arcane skills will get you the previous data more easily, provided you can accept the…"negligible" error.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Ouch …?!

Something just hit your head hard. You look up to find the greeting of a black star.

…You feel that if you don't decide soon, your fragile neck will have to retire early—actually, would that be so bad?

Wooden Disc

COL-307021

Under the cloth is a wooden disc full of vine-like patterns—the flowers of the mandrake.

You chose the easiest way. Has anyone ever mentioned your lack of adventure and patience?

You put a piece of paper on the disk, and trace a circle on it.

You close your eyes and relax, allowing the power from beyond your mind to take over your arm. You hear the paper rustling, a masterpiece is in the making.

A moment later, your hand stops, as if the strings controlling it were broken.

You open your eyes and see an absurd, unusual painting. It looks just like a mural from ancient times.

You touch it, imprinting the drawing in your mind, and close your eyes again.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Phew… Now concentrate. Imagine the secondary star orbiting the white dwarf…

The scenario of your dreams begins to play out in your mind.

Kumar: A podium, dazzling spotlights. Kumar rises from her seat, and a shower of applause.

Kumar: A smile graces her face, the usual indifference is gone without a trace.

Kaalaa Baunaa: No, no ... Try again.

The scene of your dreams begins to reappear in your mind...

You concentrate, but the sound of a flushing toilet is coming from the distance...

Water spirals down the toilet. Two black spheres are carried by the current, between them a bottomless darkness...

Kaalaa Baunaa: What's this...?

Clearly, the sound of the water has created a strange image in your meditation.

But soon you notice that the trajectory of the spheres in the water looks just like—

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

The long face will do you no good. Record the precious data before it goes away.

Documents

COL-307022

You drive to the observatory and feel your way into the moldy reference room. This smell can ruin your appetite for days.

Cheer up. Look at you, sneaking into the reference room in the middle of night, how adventurous you have become!

Kaalaa Baunaa: Ugh. At least it's not as bad as Kumar's bedroom...

Kaalaa Baunaa: So, the past data of the secondary star is...

As you move the pile of documents, a swarm of bugs pours out from the bottom.

Kaalaa Baunaa: NO!!!

For a moment, you wish you had a torch so you could burn the place down and kill these cute little buggers.

You see? The tedious life of a researcher has turned you into a child devoid of compassion and sympathy!

Kaalaa Baunaa: *sigh* ...I can do this.

You tiptoe, hold your breath, and rummage through the data books on the floor.

You pick up a bounty of records, and soon your bag is filled with all the data logs you need.

Kaalaa Baunaa: *panting*

After escaping the insects' nest, sweet air fills your lungs.

Such an epic adventure in search of truth should be etched into the annals of history.

Epilogue: Either This or That

COL-307023

Kaalaa Baunaa: These data ... The orbital movement of the secondary star was even more extreme than it is now?!

As you read the data, sweat begins to run down your cheeks.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It was even closer to the white dwarf in the past ... until it reached a minimum distance and returned to its orbit?!

Kaalaa Baunaa: My prediction...is wrong?

You know what this can mean, the endless toil of starting over again, not unlike a Sisyphean punishment...

Kaalaa Baunaa: No, no, something must be wrong with these data, either the observer or my mistake ...

You eagerly want to prove the data is wrong, but the copy of data for comparison is stored in the Banner University library.

Unfortunately it's already late at night, and the library is closed ...

You're itching to act. It will be a sleepless night if you don't get an answer.

Why hesitate?

...

...

Library

Kaalaa Baunaa: Ha...!

You sneak into the library, which is quiet as a graveyard.

You find the data and quickly flip through the pages, noticing that there are blank spots at where important data should be.

Kaalaa Baunaa: These are...remnants of an erasure.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The owner of this data book had meticulously recorded the deduction process of the data set, only to later delete this part of the data completely...

Kaalaa Baunaa: This missing data could either completely overturn my research, or finally prove my findings!

Kaalaa Baunaa: Unbelievable. He must have known that I would find this place...

Kaalaa Baunaa: I'm sure he knew how important this data was.

Kaalaa Baunaa: What compelled him to do all this?

"In arrogance, all is beneath you. In humility, nothing eludes you." You see a familiar maxim taped to the bookshelf.

You lower your head and see the corner of a book by your feet.

The answer you've been looking for.

You open the data book, and soon see the familiar signature of the observer.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

Ironically, it reads "Kumar".

But yet...she was always been the one who supported your predictions the most.

The star hanging above your head wobbles and sways...

3#1

Prologue: The Fading Stars

COL-307024

Kaalaa Baunaa: According to Kumar's past observational data, the secondary star's trajectory changes periodically.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It approaches the white dwarf until a minimum distance, and then the entire orbital trajectory begins to change.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Then the supernova explosion I inferred would be nothing more than an absurd conjecture. All my previous research would become a pile of waste paper...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kumar, what were you thinking?

Kaalaa Baunaa: If my conjecture is wrong, there was no point in hiding it.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Allowing me to go further and further down the wrong path, all that wasted time and money... What was in it for her?

Kaalaa Baunaa: It seems I'll have to observe it myself...

To prove your mistake, just observe the secondary star, on its nodal day, and you'll have the answer.

Kaalaa Baunaa: And the nodal day is...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Tomorrow?!

How fortunate... Who else could personally experience both the confirmation and the collapse of their work in just a few days?

There's no time to waste. The most pressing matter now is to choose a telescope for observation, which is your specialty...

Kaalaa Baunaa: The optical telescope, although hampered by haze, is still the most widely used tool for everyday observations.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Simple and affordable. I remember Gaurav sending one to his grandmother in Mawlynnong...

Kaalaa Baunaa: The X-ray telescope can only detect X-rays emitted after the white dwarf's eruption. But it's still far from time...

Kaalaa Baunaa: And radio telescope ... it can observe the radio waves emitted by distant stars, unaffected by weather and atmosphere...

The celestial body hanging overhead gradually expands, like a canvas of darkness.

Looks like its patience is running out.

You look at the thick clouds, deep in thought.

Optical Telescope

COL-307025

You head straight for the optical telescope at the observatory. That's where you met Kumar for the first time. You will never forget that day.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Why did she conceal the observed data?

Kaalaa Baunaa: She must have known my conjecture was...probably wrong from the start.

You touch the timeworn telescope, wondering if it can tell you the answer.

Observatory

Little Kaalaa: ...

Kumar: Child, how long have you been here?

Kumar: You would like to see it, right?

You bobbed your head hesitantly, like an indecisive puppy wagging its tail.

She gently moved aside, stepping back to make room.

You clenched your fists. That was the first time you wanted to touch something beyond your reach, which unexpectedly, led you to a future you had never imagined.

You got onto the stage, and brought your eye close to the gateway to the universe ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

You understand this place won't help you with the problem. This is just a visit for you to reminisce.

Well, at least it helped you remember a few things.

X-ray Telescope

COL-307026

The X-ray telescope—Kumar often used this as a touchstone for spotting the gifted.

Are you really going to choose this?

Is your memory failing you? A researcher's brain can't be THIS smooth.

Let's take a little trip down memory lane.

Kumar: So none of you know what it is?

The classroom fell silent. The students stared at the arrogant instructor, clueless.

Kumar: Heh. It's ridiculous that Admissions would let you students with no common sense get into my classroom.

Kumar: It seems I'm expected to stuff the wonder of the celestial bodies into your empty heads.

Kaalaa Baunaa: An X-ray telescope.

You raised your hand, giving the answer.

Kumar: Hm?

She looked at you with interest.

Kaalaa Baunaa: This telescope can receive X-rays emitted by celestial bodies for analysis and observation.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's launched into space, and has an extremely long observation distance.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But it doesn't perform well when observing celestial bodies that emit weak rays, such as a stable white dwarf.

Your expectant gaze met her eyes, which held the hint of a smile.

Kumar: Not bad. At least you're not as empty-headed.

Kumar: Please come see me after the class.

Since then, the other students have secretly called you and Kumar the "Siamese Twins".

You didn't bother to deny it, because the two of you became ... almost inseparable.

The more time you spent with her, the more you became like her in temperament. Like a sponge, you began to absorb her wisdom and insight.

Yet today you come here, like one of those ignorant students—is your life a living comedy?

Radio Telescope

COL-307027

You haven't been back here for years.

When Kumar first brought you here, she saw you as her sole successor.

Kumar: Radio telescopes can receive information from even more distant celestial bodies through radio radiation.

Kumar: Unlike an optical telescope, it won't give you just a rough picture of the universe.

Kumar: The receiver processes the radiation signals and converts them into their final form for recording and display.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Which means ... it works no matter what the weather or the atmosphere is like.

Kumar: Yes, but it is not an extension of the human eye. It presents the star to us from a different angle—in precise data.

Kumar: For most people, numbers on paper and stars in the sky are nothing alike, but the accurate data to us is the same as the stunning night sky to them.

Kumar: This is our first lesson, child—the moment you enter the research institute, the glittering stars in your eyes will cease to twinkle.

Kumar: The vast universe will become...tedious. When you look up at the night sky, you will find the primal thrill slowly leaving you. And that is the price of reaching for its secrets.

She taught you everything she knew and treated you as her own child.

Until finally, you realized she was just nurturing another version of herself.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The switch ...

You turn on the radio telescope and hold your breath, getting ready for the final reveal...

Is this a cruel joke of Kumar's, or a ridiculous blunder?

Epilogue: The Fading Stars

COL-307028

You drag your weary body back to the institute. Your brain is groaning, craving sleep like never before.

According to the radio telescope's observations, Kumar's data was correct every step of the way.

The observation results are a death sentence, condemning you as a failure, your research nothing more than an absurd mistake.

And Kumar had known this all along, but remained silent. After all, it was your research.

Electricity arcs inside the light bulb, and the room pulsates between light and darkness.

It's an old problem with the wiring—tolerating its inconvenience has long been the consensus.

But the flaws will pile up like an insurmountable debt, until everything wobbles and falls apart, beyond salvation.

The darkness descends upon the room like an unpleasant intruder.

It is heavy, as are your feelings.

There is no one around. Holding the report tightly, you close your eyes … and open them again.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I should have known…this entire research was just a small part of her plan.

Kaalaa Baunaa: From the moment I entered the institute, she no longer saw me as a student…

Flames ignite, crawling up the paper.

You know this is just one insignificant segment among the countless, meaningless threads between mankind and arcanists.

A journey left unfinished, a chapter left unconcluded, and a theory left unproofed…

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kumar, I hope this is the last lesson you left me…

The report burns. Words turn to ash and dissolve into the air…

"The secondary star's trajectory is consistent, but there are small anomalies in some of the observational data. The amount of such anomalous data is scarce, and was considered an observational error."

Kaalaa Baunaa: ?! …Wait!

Kaalaa Baunaa: In that case…

Kaalaa Baunaa: …!

You try to put out the fire, but what's left of the report turns to dust in the palm of your hand.

3#1

Prologue: Celestial Bodies and Mythologies

COL-307029

Biting your finger, you stare at the empty table.

Not all is lost, though. There are still copies of the report archived at the institute.

Kaalaa Baunaa: If that was an observational error, why were there the same anomalies in Kumar's data as well?

Kaalaa Baunaa: I hadn't noticed this before... The dataset Kumar obtained through arcane skills also has an eerily similar **3%** error!

Kaalaa Baunaa: A 3% error... At the inquiry, Kapur and Datt also expressed doubts about it.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Is this a coincidence...? No, it can't be.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Unless...Kumar and I fell into the same trap, and made the same mistake!

You feel a tremor, as if electricity is running through you.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Is it possible the changes of the orbit follow a certain pattern?

You push the desk and chairs aside, and spread all the observation logs on the floor.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ...

You can't figure out what common factor is influencing your research and Kumar's. The truth is, many wrong false conclusions stem from a lack of respect for coincidences.

Kaalaa Baunaa: No way ... These "errors" happened at nearly the same time in every dataset...

You are determined to get to the bottom of this once and for all.

There is work to be done.

Dusty Bookshelf

COL-307030

Morning light spills on the ground. You spent the entire night analyzing the data, but found nothing.

Gulping down a cup of coffee, you lean against a file cabinet and watch the world outside awaken. There isn't much time left.

Wait, what's that book on the ground? You seem to remember it ...

Kaalaa Baunaa: ... I thought I lost it.

"A Brief History of Celestial Bodies (Mythological Compilation)". You pick it up and pat the dust off it.

The spine is labeled "Banner Elementary School Library". This library really should put you on their blacklist.

Kaalaa Baunaa: "The Origin of Faust Stars"...

Kaalaa Baunaa: "In the beginning, the universe was shapeless, dark and silent, like a bottomless well."

Kaalaa Baunaa: "A speck of dust, falling into the endless darkness, was the primordial Faust."

Kaalaa Baunaa: "He marked out his territory, safeguarding peace and order as would a king, but it was a land without subjects."

A crooked, gray scribble is scrawled below the words.

Kaalaa Baunaa: This writing...

You remember it was written with a pencil shorter than your pinky.

Kaalaa Baunaa: "He marked out his territory, safeguarding peace and order as would a king, but it was a land without subjects."

You held the book, while she propped her chin attentively.

Girl: Wow, just like Teacher Sakash from our hut...

Girl: She told us there was nothing in the hut at first—just some rotten planks.

Girl: No one wanted to learn from her... They all said, instead of staring at numbers, they might as well go herd cows to earn some money for chapati!

Kaalaa Baunaa: That's a shame, she sounds like a good teacher.

Girl: Heh heh, don't worry. It was only temporary.

Girl: Later, the cowherd Salman stood quietly by the window and left a ruler behind. Soon after, Taseem from the cart driver's family brought over a table and bench each missing a leg... Over time, more and more people came.

Girl: Teacher Sakash told us there are more stars in the sky than grains of rice in a pot.

Girl: I haven't counted the stars, but I sure have counted grains of rice. Teacher Sakash is absolutely right!

She scratched her head.

Girl: But then she said, the rice grains in the pot will one day outnumber the stars in the sky... That really confuses me.

Kaalaa Baunaa: You can come with her next time, you'll be very welcome.

She turned her face away dejectedly.

Girl: It's too high, and too far from here. Besides, I came to count the stars and I've already got my answer.

Girl: Teacher Sakash is wrong. There are so many stars in the sky that grains of rice can never outnumber them.

Girl: "Teachers make mistakes too", that's what she told me.

She took out a pencil and left a dot to mark the end of the story.

Girl: I should get going. Let's stop here for today, thank you...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Wait, when will you come back again?

Girl: I...I don't know. The hut is getting demolished, so we're looking for a new place.

Girl: Once we find a new hut, I'll come back to find you! I-if I don't come back...

She wrote something on the page, one stroke at a time.

Girl: You can come find me here!

Kaalaa Baunaa: Yet I never saw her again...

You turn the page and find that part of the book gone.

Something urges you on, like a...faint sense of guilt.

Leaning down, you hold back the urge to retch, looking for the missing page with the address.

Loose Page: Two

COL-307031

Kumar: ... If we completely rely on human research methods, with our funding, we probably can't even secure the necessary equipment.

Kumar: Make good use of shortcuts, child. Don't try to win by their rules alone.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But data obtained through arcane skills isn't entirely accurate... It will directly affect the research results.

Kumar: I'm telling you, cast aside your preferences. You can use human observational data to validate your research, while using arcane skills to always stay one step ahead of them.

She sat back down, burying her head in the piles of documents.

Kumar: Why are you still here?

Kaalaa Baunaa: I...left a book here.

Kumar: Is it this one? I thought it belonged to that dimwitted intern.

She threw the book at you, its pages rustling as it fell to the ground.

Kumar: Sorry, I tore out some pages to use as draft paper. You can buy another copy if you need it. Just make a note in the research budget.

She didn't look up the whole time.

Kaalaa Baunaa: There's no need...

You picked up the pages and hurried out of that stifling office.

The last page is still in the book, but some pages in the middle are missing.

You push away the desk—chewing gum, scraps of paper, pellets of feces, cereal bars...and a sleeping rat.

There is an unfinished page in its arms. Thank goodness it's not a fast eater.

Loose Page: One

COL-307032

You snatch the page from the rat. It squeaks and scurries out of the office. Well ... hopefully you don't feel guilty about that.

Kaalaa Baunaa: This is probably the missing page ...

Flattening and unfolding it, you restore the crumpled page to its original form.

But the address on it is nowhere to be found.

Kaalaa Baunaa: What is going on...

Kaalaa Baunaa: I remember...!

Yes, you remember that dimwitted intern.

Kaalaa Baunaa: That's it for today. You can go now, Gaurav.

Intern Gaurav: O-okay, Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa... But I think I'll stay a while longer. I need to double check this data on the spectral lines.

Kaalaa Baunaa: See you tomorrow then.

A hand stopped you.

Intern Gaurav: Sorry, is this your book ... Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa?

Kaalaa Baunaa: Yes...it is.

Intern Gaurav: My mother used to read me this story. I'm very sorry...I flipped through it just now without permission.

Intern Gaurav: This page seems to have data copied down by Ms. Kumar...

...That unpleasant feeling again.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Get rid of it for me.

You remember leaving without looking back.

The truth comes out. It was you who erased the address and the data.

But something else springs to mind.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Wait, wait... "Data on the spectral lines"?

A kernel of truth emerges.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Gaurav was actually able to distinguish single stars from binary stars!? Then... his data wasn't wrong!

With this realization, you run back to the lab, take out the diagrams, and match them up one by one...

Another answer emerges in your mind.

Epilogue: Celestial Bodies and Mythologies

COL-307033

Kaalaa Baunaa: Gaurav had been meticulously recording data all along, he never missed a thing.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It was me and Kumar, using data obtained through arcane skills, who misled the whole team!

The truth no longer eludes you, but it is too late.

You flip the papers back and forth, your eyes darting from place to place.

Kaalaa Baunaa: No, it's not that simple... With the data we got through arcane skills, combined with Gaurav's analysis, there's a new possibility...!

Kaalaa Baunaa: Another undiscovered star!

Kaalaa Baunaa: What if this star only appears at the orbit's nodal points of change, and is beyond detection at other times?

You circle the nodal points, overturning your research step by step. In the face of discovering a new star, this labor seems inconsequential.

Kaalaa Baunaa: An undiscovered star that intermittently attracts the secondary star... Whenever the binary star is on the verge of a supernova, it pulls the secondary star back into the proper orbit.

Kaalaa Baunaa: This game is more interesting than you thought, Kumar.

Leaving the mess in the institution behind, you go back to the observatory. The star above your head happily follows as an approval of your decision.

Aside from avoiding the peaks of solar radio emissions, the radio telescope has no other limitations.

Your heart is being squeezed, as if you were holding it in your hand.

Kaalaa Baunaa: So, the conclusion is ...

3#1

Prologue: Dusts and Stars

COL-307034

...

Under the night sky, William Herschel's symphony echoes throughout the observatory.

In 1758, when the musician was at the concert hall, he probably never imagined that he would one day accomplish what many astronomers have struggled a lifetime to achieve...

Discovering Uranus, the seventh planet in the solar system.

It all started with a popular science book—which absurdly claimed that there were human-like creatures living on comets and the sun.

So he tried to look for these living things on the distant celestial bodies...through a refracting telescope.

The blurred images disappointed him greatly. He had no choice but to spend great efforts and a large sum of money building his own telescope.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But he didn't find any life on the celestial bodies. Instead, he discovered a planet overlooked and neglected by astronomers, and became famous overnight, attracting worldwide attention.

Kaalaa Baunaa: "You fear the loss of status so much, thinking its benefits irreplaceable; yet the benefits often find another way, befalling you."

Kaalaa Baunaa: "Fate loves this kind of reversal, casting the seeds of hope in one direction, only to grow a towering tree in a place you never expected."

Night falls, revealing the stars in the sky. You sigh as the boundless universe has not given you the answer you expected.

The god of fortune does not smile on you; an undiscovered star simply does not exist...

Constellation

COL-307035

On the dark pall of the night sky, specks of light appear one after another.

Orion, Canis Major... they are made up of irregular celestial bodies. People named them in imitation of nature.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I negated my own theory and rebuilt it again and again. Every time I found the spark of hope in the darkness, the truth just put it out against my will.

You lean against the railing of the observatory, a vast, dense forest lies below. You stop observing and look up at the night sky you've missed for so long.

How many people have been inspired by this celestial wonder and entered the realm of astronomy?

Luminosity, distance, lifespan—they measure these beautiful celestial bodies by human standards, describe them in words and numbers, and assign them coordinates.

Kaalaa Baunaa: If the arcanists of Mesopotamia saw what human astronomy is like now, they would go mad and try to tear it all down...

Kaalaa Baunaa: They observed tens of thousands of stars, called these star clusters living beings, and eventually built a magnificent celestial system.

Kaalaa Baunaa: They recorded all the astronomical phenomena and compiled them into records that guided mankind, only to be sentenced to death for their predictions and forecasts ...

Kumar stood in front of the podium. That was the only time you saw her emotionally moved.

Kumar: ...Three months ago, archaeologists discovered cuneiform tablets near the Tigris River.

Kumar: The Mesopotamian astronomers who were punished by death left these words on the tablets —

Kumar: "We once measured the infinite with our insignificant bodies, and recorded eternity in our fleeting existence."

Kumar: "No need to remember, no need to pander. We perish, but truth remains eternal..."

Kumar: No matter where you end up in the future, keep these words to heart ... They are the very essence of our existence.

Celestial Body

COL-307036

What is the price we must pay for a kernel of truth?

If our theory of lifelong devotion is proven wrong, how are we to not collapse and still carry on?

The pain is an inevitable cost that we must bear. Only by concluding this chapter can we move on to a new path, perhaps one that leads to the truth.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I think I'm ready ...

You reach out, stroking the celestial body above your head, as if you've reached an understanding with it.

It starts to ascend, first floating in the air, then the sky, and at last towards the end of sight ...

Having abandoned a theory doomed to failure, you can barely contain your sadness. Nevertheless, you breathe a long sigh of relief.

Why do you want to look at the universe?

Girl: It's the one thing that no one can take from me, um ... one of the two things, I still have this broken shirt!

Girl: Stars don't die, and they don't need to eat. No one can occupy them by spending money.

Intern Gaurav: Th-They are so beautiful ... Hmm? Not a good reason?

Intern Gaurav: Well ... My dadi is in Mawlynnong. The stars are the only one thing we can watch together when we're on the phone.

Researcher Himani: The sink full of greasy dishes, endless housework ... I want to run away from them.

Researcher Himani: Even though life was filled with unstoppable snores and cries, I knew I was living for myself as long as I still saw the stars.

Kumar: ...

Kumar: Because they are just, there.

Little Kaalaa: When I am hungry, I always lie on the roof and look at the stars.

Little Kaalaa: They twinkle just like diamonds ... I wish I could pick them off one day and put them all in my pocket.

Little Kaalaa: Then I'll exchange them for a neer dosa as large as a corral!

Their shadows overlap, then fade away one by one.

You reach out, framing an area with your index and thumb—the location of the White Dwarf FYDL 82A.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I will remember you, little star ...

It senses your existence and starts to flicker ...

But something is not right, it gets brighter and brighter until it becomes the size of a pebble.

Kaalaa Baunaa: A supernova?!

You stare in disbelief. The blinding light engulfs everything in sight.

It burns your skin, and stings your face...!

Epilogue: Dusts and Stars

COL-307037

Kaalaa Baunaa: Ugh! *pants*

You wake up startled, shirt soaked in sweat.

Intern Gaurav: Are-Are you alright, Ms. Kaalaa Baunaa?

Gaurav stands by the window, holding the curtains.

You block the glaring sunlight with your hand and tell him to pull back the curtains.

Kaalaa Baunaa: ... A dream?

You support your head, still feeling dizzy.

The research report on the desk is as fresh as new. No arcanist's name is signed on it.

You are still safely hidden, disguised as a human.

Kaalaa Baunaa: I remember that book, it should be here somewhere...

New thoughts arise, urging you to take a different path from the one in the dream.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Found it.

On the page, what's left of the writing is still vaguely discernible.

This is an appointment long overdue.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Gaurav, I'd like to ask you a favor.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Please drive me to this address, the car keys are on the table.

You point to the faded writing, as if she were still stubbornly inviting you to come.

Intern Gaurav: O-okay...

Kaalaa Baunaa: Also—

You put a form on his desk.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Have you...considered becoming formal researcher?

3#2